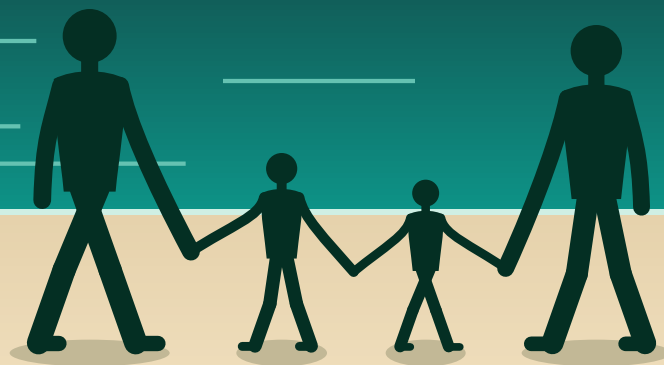


Plan the Fam

The Essential Estate Planning Guide for Families



Within this guide:

- ✓ Take the steps toward building a robust estate plan
- ✓ How to prepare for attorney meetings
- ✓ Save hundreds, even thousands of dollars, on legal fees

PLAN THE FAM

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Chapter 1: Why Estate Planning Matters for Young Families

If you're reading this, you already know something important: your family's future matters. But here's what might surprise you—estate planning isn't just for wealthy retirees. It's actually most urgent for young families with children.

The Wake-Up Call

Imagine this scenario: You and your spouse are in a car accident. Who takes care of your kids? Who manages the life insurance payout? Who makes medical decisions if you're incapacitated? Without proper planning, these decisions go to a judge who doesn't know your family.

The Real Cost of Waiting

Many young families put off estate planning because:

- ✗ “We don't have enough assets yet”
- ✗ “Attorneys are too expensive (\$2,000–\$5,000)”
- ✗ “We're too young to worry about this”
- ✗ “It's too complicated and overwhelming”

But here's the truth: If you have children, you have everything worth protecting. And with the right preparation (which this guide provides), you can save money on attorney fees while protecting what matters most: your family.

What This Guide Will Do for You

By the end of this guide, you will:

- ✓ Understand whether you need a trust, a will, or both
- ✓ Know exactly which documents your family needs
- ✓ Have completed worksheets ready for your attorney
- ✓ Save \$500–\$1,500 in legal fees by being prepared
- ✓ Peace of mind that your children are protected

Chapter 2: Understanding Revocable Living Trusts

What is a Revocable Living Trust?

A revocable living trust is a legal document that holds ownership of your assets during your lifetime and specifies who gets them after you die—all while avoiding the time-consuming and expensive probate court process.

Think of it like this: Instead of you personally owning your house, your car, and your bank accounts, your trust owns them. You control the trust completely while you're alive (you're the 'trustee'), so nothing changes day-to-day. But when you pass away, everything transfers to your beneficiaries immediately, without court involvement.

Key Benefits for Young Families

Benefit	Why It Matters for You
Avoid Probate	Your family gets assets in weeks, not 6-18 months. No court fees (\$3,000-\$7,000 saved).
Privacy Protection	Unlike wills, trusts aren't public record. Protects your children's inheritance from public scrutiny.
Incapacity Planning	If you're in an accident, your co-trustee (usually spouse) can manage finances immediately.
Guardian Provisions	Ensures the person raising your kids also has access to funds to care for them properly.
Creditor Protection	Properly structured trusts can protect inheritance from your children's future creditors or divorces.

What 'Revocable' Means

'Revocable' simply means you can change or cancel the trust anytime while you're alive and mentally competent. Bought a new house? Just add it to the trust. Had another child? Update the beneficiaries. Changed your mind about the guardian? Revise it. This flexibility is crucial for young families whose circumstances change frequently.

Common Misconceptions

Myth #1: 'Trusts are only for rich people.' **Reality:** If you own a home and have kids, a trust can save your family thousands in probate costs and months of waiting.

Myth #2: 'Once I create a trust, I lose control of my assets.' **Reality:** You maintain complete control. You can buy, sell, refinance, and manage assets exactly as before.

Myth #3: 'A trust eliminates the need for a will.' **Reality:** You still need a 'pour-over will' to catch any assets you forgot to put in the trust, plus it names guardians for your children.

Myth #4: 'Once our plan is signed, we're finished.' **Reality:** A plan is only as current as your life. A new baby, a move to another state, a new house, or a guardian whose circumstances change can all make yesterday's documents the wrong ones.

Myth #5: 'My spouse automatically inherits everything anyway.' **Reality:** Not always. In many states, part of your estate passes to your children instead of your spouse, and a judge decides who manages their share until they come of age.

Chapter 3: Trust vs. Will - What's Right for You?

Choosing between a trust and a will is one of the most consequential decisions you will make for your family. Let's break down when you need what.

The Decision Tree

Your Situation	Recommendation
Married, own home, have kids under 18	Trust + Will (pour-over will naming guardians)
Single parent, own property, have kids	Trust + Will (critical for guardian designation)
Married, rent apartment, minimal assets	Will only (trust optional but beneficial)
Own property in multiple states	Definitely need a trust (avoids probate in each state)
Blended family with kids from prior marriages	Trust + Will (protects everyone's interests)
Assets under \$50,000, no real estate	Will may be sufficient

Why Most Young Families Need Both

Here's what catches people off guard: Even with a trust, you still need a will. Here's why:

- 1. Guardian Designation:** Only a will can legally name guardians for your minor children. This is non-negotiable if you're a parent.
- 2. Pour-Over Protection:** A 'pour-over will' acts as a safety net, transferring any assets you forgot to put in your trust into the trust after you die.
- 3. Personal Property:** Your jewelry, family heirlooms, and personal items are typically easier to distribute through a will.

The Cost-Benefit Analysis

Scenario	Will Only	Trust + Will	Do Nothing
Attorney Fees	\$500-\$1,500	\$2,000-\$5,000	\$0
Probate Costs	\$3,000-\$7,000	\$0	\$3,000-\$10,000+
Time to Distribute Assets	6-18 months	2-6 weeks	12-24+ months
Court Involvement	Extensive	Minimal	Extensive + messy
Guardian Fights	Possible	Prevented	Likely
Total Cost to Family	\$3,500-\$8,500	\$2,000-\$5,000	\$10,000-\$50,000

Key Takeaway: A trust costs more upfront but saves your family money, time, and heartache. For most families with children and a home, it's worth the investment.

Chapter 4: Essential Documents Every Family Needs

Beyond the trust and will, there are several other critical documents that protect your family. Think of these as your complete estate planning toolkit.

The Five-Document Foundation

Document	What It Does	Why You Need It
1. Revocable Living Trust	Manages and distributes your assets	Avoids probate, provides incapacity planning
2. Pour-Over Will	Catches missed assets, names guardians	Safety net + guardian designation (CRITICAL for parents)
3. Durable Power of Attorney (Financial)	Lets someone manage your finances if you're incapacitated	Without it, spouse needs court order to pay your bills
4. Healthcare Power of Attorney	Designates who makes medical decisions	Ensures spouse/family can make critical health choices
5. Living Will / Advance Healthcare Directive	States your end-of-life wishes	Prevents family conflict during medical crises

Additional Documents to Consider

HIPAA Authorization: Allows designated people to access your medical records. Critical in emergencies when doctors need your medical history.

Letter of Intent for Guardians: Not legally binding, but provides guidance to your children's guardians about your wishes for raising them (education, religion, values, activities).

Digital Estate Plan: Lists passwords, accounts, social media, and instructions for digital assets. Your family will thank you for this.

Life Insurance Trust (ILIT): For high net worth families potentially subject to estate tax, funneling life insurance proceeds into an irrevocable life insurance trust can help descendants prepare for estate taxes. Discuss with your attorney if applicable.

Real-World Example: Why All Five Matter

Sarah and Mike had a will naming guardians for their two kids, but no other documents. When Sarah had a stroke at 35:

- Mike couldn't access Sarah's individual bank account (no financial POA) and had to go to court
- Doctors wouldn't discuss Sarah's condition with Mike's parents who were helping (no HIPAA authorization)
- Sarah recovered, but the family spent \$8,000 in legal fees and three months in court for something a \$200 Power of Attorney would have prevented

Priya and Daniel signed a trust when their daughter was born, then never transferred anything into it. When Daniel died unexpectedly at 41:

- The house was still titled in their personal names, so it went through probate anyway
- Priya waited eleven months and paid roughly \$6,000 in court and attorney fees to retitle a home the trust was supposed to protect
- The trust document itself was fine — the funding paperwork was the piece nobody finished

James, a single father, named his brother as guardian in his will but never created a trust or named a trustee. When James died in a car accident:

- His brother was confirmed as guardian but had no authority over the \$400,000 life insurance payout, which went directly to James's 9-year-old son
- The court appointed a conservator who charged annual fees and required approval for ordinary expenses like summer camp
- The full balance is scheduled to be handed to his son at 18, with none of the guardrails James assumed were in place

Chapter 5: Guardian Selection for Your Children

This is the hardest decision you'll make in estate planning. It's also the most important one. Let's make it easier.

The Guardian Decision Framework

When choosing a guardian, consider these factors in order of priority:

Factor	Questions to Ask Yourself
1. Values & Parenting Style	Do they share your core values? Would they raise your kids with similar principles?
2. Stability & Commitment	Are they willing and able to take on this role? Do they have stable housing/employment?
3. Age & Health	Will they be physically able to care for young children for the next 10-15 years?
4. Existing Relationship	Do your kids already know and trust them? How strong is the bond?
5. Location	Would your kids have to move? Change schools? Leave friends?
6. Financial Capacity	Can they afford to raise additional children? (You can provide funds via trust)
7. Other Children	How many kids do they already have? Would adding yours overwhelm them?

Guardian vs. Trustee: A Critical Distinction

Many families assume the person raising their kids should also manage the inheritance money. This isn't always the best choice. Here's why you might split these roles:

Guardian (raises the kids): Your sister who's amazing with children but terrible with money

Trustee (manages the money): Your financially savvy brother who's not a 'kid person'

This way, the guardian gets funds to care for the kids, but someone responsible manages the assets. Prevents potential financial abuse or mismanagement while ensuring kids are raised by the right person.

The Backup Guardian Question

Always name backup guardians. Life happens—your first choice might predecease you, become unable to serve, or their circumstances might change dramatically. Name at least two backups.

What to Discuss with Your Chosen Guardian

Before naming someone as guardian, have this conversation:

- ✓ Are you willing to take on this responsibility if something happens to us?
- ✓ We've set aside [amount] in a trust to help with expenses. You'd work with [trustee] to access funds.
- ✓ Here are our wishes regarding education, religion, activities, and values.
- ✓ We'll provide a detailed letter of intent with specifics about the kids' routines, preferences, and needs.
- ✓ Would you be comfortable with our backup guardians if you're unable to serve?

Important: If your chosen guardian is uncomfortable or hesitant, that's critical information. Pick someone else. You want someone who is honored and committed, not obligated.

Chapter 6: Supporting Documents for a Complete Estate Plan

A revocable living trust is the centerpiece of your estate plan, but it doesn't work alone. A handful of companion documents fill the gaps a trust can't cover — naming guardians, giving someone authority the moment you can't act for yourself, and making sure your wishes are honored if you're ever incapacitated. This chapter walks through each one so you understand what your attorney will prepare and why it matters.

Pour-Over Will

A pour-over will works alongside your trust rather than replacing it. Any asset you acquire but never formally retitle into the trust's name — a new car, a bank account you forgot to update, a check that arrives after you pass — gets “poured over” into the trust through this will, where it's then distributed according to your trust's instructions.

More importantly for parents, a pour-over will is the **only** document that can legally name guardians for your minor children. A trust cannot do this. If you skip this document, a court decides who raises your kids — regardless of how detailed your trust is.

What it typically includes: Guardian and backup guardian nominations, instructions to transfer any outstanding assets into your trust, and an executor to oversee that process through probate if needed.

Durable Financial Power of Attorney

This document authorizes someone you trust (your “agent”) to manage your financial affairs — paying bills, filing taxes, accessing bank accounts, managing investments — if you become unable to do so yourself. “Durable” means the authority stays in effect even if you become incapacitated, which is precisely when it's needed most.

Without one, your spouse or family may need to petition a court for conservatorship just to pay your mortgage or access a joint account that's only in your name — a process that can take weeks and cost thousands in legal fees.

Key decision: You can make the authority effective immediately upon signing, or “springing” — only taking effect once a doctor confirms incapacity. Discuss which structure fits your comfort level with your attorney.

Healthcare Power of Attorney

Also called a healthcare proxy or medical power of attorney, this document names someone to make medical decisions on your behalf if you're unable to communicate your own wishes — due to surgery, an accident, or a serious illness. This is separate from the financial power of attorney; many families name the same person for both, but you can split the roles.

Your healthcare agent can consent to or refuse treatment, choose providers and facilities, and advocate for you in situations your advance directive doesn't explicitly cover.

HIPAA Authorization

Federal privacy law prevents doctors and hospitals from sharing your medical information with anyone — including your spouse or parents — without your explicit authorization. A HIPAA authorization form grants specific people the legal right to access your medical records and speak with your care team.

This is easy to overlook because it feels redundant with a healthcare power of attorney, but they serve different purposes: the power of attorney grants decision-making authority, while the HIPAA authorization grants access to information. You generally need both, and many attorneys combine them into a single signed document.

Advance Healthcare Directive (Living Will)

An advance directive, often called a living will, states your own wishes about end-of-life care in writing — whether you want life support, artificial nutrition, or resuscitation under specific circumstances. It removes the burden from your family of guessing what you would have wanted during an already difficult moment.

This document works together with your healthcare power of attorney: the directive states your wishes, and your healthcare agent carries them out and fills in any gaps the document doesn't address.

How These Documents Work Together

Document	What It Covers	When It Takes Effect
Pour-Over Will	Names guardians; catches assets left out of the trust	After death
Durable Financial POA	Authorizes someone to manage your finances	Immediately or upon incapacity
Healthcare POA	Names your medical decision-maker	Upon incapacity
HIPAA Authorization	Grants access to your medical records and information	Immediately, as needed
Advance Directive / Living Will	States your end-of-life care wishes	Upon incapacity or terminal diagnosis

Together with your revocable living trust, these five documents form a complete plan: one that protects your assets, names who raises your children, and ensures someone you trust can act — financially and medically — the moment you're unable to act for yourself. Chapter 7 will help you gather everything your attorney needs to draft all of these documents in a single, efficient meeting.

Chapter 7: Asset Inventory Checklist

This chapter includes worksheets you can complete and bring to your attorney. Completing these in advance can save you \$500-\$1,500 in billable hours.

Real Estate & Property

Property Type	Address	Loan ID	Mortgage Servicer	Approx. Home Value
Primary Residence				
Secondary Residence				
Rental Property				

Business Ownership

Complete one section for each business you own an interest in.

Business Detail	Your Information
Business Name	
Entity Type (LLC, S-Corp, LP)	
Ownership Percentage	
Other Owners	
Creditors / Business Debts	
Approximate Value	
Buy-Sell Agreement? Yes / No	

Financial Accounts

Account Type	Institution & Account #	Approx. Value	Beneficiary?
Checking Accounts			Yes / No
Savings Accounts			Yes / No
Brokerage Accounts			Yes / No
ESOP / NQSO / ISO			Yes / No
ESOP / NQSO / ISO			Yes / No
401(k) / 403(b)			Yes / No
401(k) / 403(b)			Yes / No
IRA / Roth IRA			Yes / No
IRA / Roth IRA			Yes / No
SEP IRA			Yes / No
SEP IRA			Yes / No
529 College Savings			Yes / No
529 College Savings			Yes / No
529 College Savings			Yes / No
HSA			Yes / No
Cryptocurrency			Yes / No

Critical Note on Beneficiaries: Retirement accounts and life insurance pass directly to named beneficiaries, OUTSIDE of your will or trust. Make sure beneficiaries are updated and match your trust plan.

Insurance Policies

Policy Type	Company & Policy #	Coverage Amount	Beneficiary
Life Insurance (You)			
Life Insurance (Spouse)			
Disability Insurance			
Long-term Care			
Other Policies			

Personal Property & Digital Assets

Vehicle (Make/VIN): _____

Vehicle (Make/VIN): _____

Vehicle (Make/VIN): _____

Jewelry/Heirlooms: _____

Collections: _____

Patents/Copyrights: _____

Digital Assets:

Email accounts: _____

Social media: _____

Cloud storage: _____

Photo libraries: _____

Cryptocurrency wallets: _____

Information Your Attorney Will Need

The documents in Chapter 6 all require the same core personal and family details. Filling in the fields below before your meeting means your attorney can draft your trust, pour-over will, powers of attorney, HIPAA authorization, and advance directive without spending billable time collecting this information from you in person.

Personal & Marital Information

Field	Your Information
Full Legal Name (You)	
Full Legal Name (Spouse/Partner)	
Date of Birth (You)	
Date of Birth (Spouse/Partner)	
Current Home Address	
Date of Marriage (if applicable)	
State of Legal Residence	
Prior Marriages / Divorces (You)	
Prior Marriages / Divorces (Spouse)	

Children Information

Full Legal Name	Date of Birth	From This Marriage?

Key People for Your Documents

Role	Full Name	Relationship	Phone / Contact
Primary Guardian			
Backup Guardian #1			
Backup Guardian #2			
Trustee (if not you/spouse)			
Successor Trustee			
Executor of Will			
Financial POA Agent			
Backup Financial POA Agent			
Healthcare POA Agent			
Backup Healthcare POA Agent			
HIPAA Authorized Person(s)			

Healthcare & Advance Directive Preferences

Field	Your Information
Primary Physician Name & Phone	
Preferred Hospital/Health System	
Life Support Preferences (general)	
Organ Donation Preference	
Religious/Cultural Considerations for Care	

Bring this completed chapter to your attorney meeting along with the rest of your asset inventory — together they give your attorney everything needed to draft your full document set in one pass.

Chapter 8: Preparing for Your Attorney Meeting

This chapter is where you save serious money. Attorneys often charge \$500 or more per hour. By preparing thoroughly, you can cut a 6-hour engagement down to 2-3 hours.

Where to Find a Qualified Estate Planning Attorney

If you don't already have an attorney in mind, here are the most reliable places to start looking:

Personal referrals: Ask your financial advisor, CPA, or insurance agent — they regularly work alongside estate planning attorneys and know who's responsive and thorough. Friends or family who've recently completed their own planning are another good source.

State bar lawyer referral service: Most state bar associations run a free or low-cost referral service that connects you with vetted attorneys who practice estate planning in your area. Search “[your state] bar association lawyer referral service.”

American College of Trust and Estate Counsel (ACTEC): A professional association of experienced trust and estate attorneys; their public directory at actec.org lists fellows by state.

Online attorney directories: Avvo, Martindale-Hubbell, and FindLaw let you filter by practice area and read client reviews and peer ratings.

Local estate planning seminars or workshops: Many firms host free informational sessions — a low-pressure way to meet an attorney and gauge their communication style before committing.

Credentials Worth Looking For

Not every attorney who offers estate planning services specializes in it. These credentials signal deeper focus in the field:

Certified Specialist in Estate Planning: Some states (California, Florida, and Texas, among others) offer a formal board certification in estate planning, trust, and probate law — a meaningful signal of focused experience.

Primary practice area listed as estate planning, trusts, or probate (not a general practice that also happens to offer it).

Pre-Meeting Preparation Checklist

- Complete asset inventory from Chapter 7
- Decide on guardian and backup guardians (have the conversation)
- Choose trustee (can be same as guardian or different)
- Gather copies of deeds to real property
- Bring life insurance policy information
- Review beneficiary designations on all accounts
- Write down any special wishes or concerns

Questions to Ask Your Attorney

Category	Questions to Ask
Costs	What's your flat fee or hourly rate? What's included? Any additional costs for revisions or funding the trust?
Timeline	How long until documents are ready? When can we start transferring assets?
Trust Funding	Will you help transfer assets into the trust, or do I do that myself? What are the steps?
Maintenance	How often should we review/update? What triggers a necessary update (new child, property, etc.)?
Coordination	Do my life insurance beneficiaries need to be the trust, or can they remain my spouse?
Out-of-State	We might move to [state]. Will this trust work there, or need revision?

Red Flags: When to Find a Different Attorney

- ✗ They can't explain things in plain English
- ✗ They push unnecessary expensive add-ons
- ✗ They don't ask about your specific family situation
- ✗ They seem rushed or dismissive of your questions
- ✗ They don't specialize in estate planning

Chapter 9: Common Mistakes to Avoid

These are the mistakes I see young families make repeatedly. Learn from others' errors:

Mistake #1: Creating the Trust but Not Funding It

The Problem: You pay \$3,000 for a trust, then never transfer your house, accounts, or assets into it. When you die, everything goes through probate anyway. The trust is worthless.

The Solution: After signing trust documents, immediately:

- Transfer home deed to the trust (your attorney can do this, or you can DIY with county recorder)
- Change bank account titles to '[Your Name], Trustee of [Trust Name]'
- Update brokerage account registrations
- Review this annually to ensure new assets are included

Mistake #2: Forgetting to Update After Major Life Changes

The Problem: You created your estate plan before your second child was born, before you bought a bigger house, before Aunt Sally (your chosen guardian) moved to Australia.

The Solution: Review and update after:

- Birth or adoption of a child
- Marriage or divorce
- Purchase of significant assets (home, business)
- Moving to a new state
- Death or incapacity of guardian/trustee
- Significant change in guardian's circumstances
- Major change in net worth

Mistake #3: Mismatched Beneficiary Designations

The Problem: Your trust says everything goes to your spouse, but your 401(k) still lists your ex-wife as beneficiary. Guess who gets your retirement account? (Spoiler: Not your spouse.)

The Solution: Retirement accounts, life insurance, and payable-on-death accounts pass OUTSIDE your will and trust. Review all beneficiary designations and coordinate with your overall plan.

Mistake #4: Choosing Guardians Without Discussing It

The Problem: You die, and your chosen guardian says 'I never agreed to this!' Now it's a court battle.

The Solution: Have the difficult conversation. If they're hesitant, pick someone else. You need commitment, not obligation.

Mistake #5: Thinking You're Too Young or Don't Have Enough Assets

The Problem: 'We'll do it when we're older' or 'We don't have enough money to bother.'

The Reality: If you have kids and a life insurance policy, you have enough to protect. A family with \$500,000 in life insurance and no estate plan is a disaster waiting to happen. Don't wait for the perfect time. The perfect time is now.

Chapter 10: State-Specific Considerations

Estate planning laws vary by state. Here are key differences that affect your planning:

Community Property vs. Common Law States

Community Property States (9)	Common Law States (41)
Arizona, California, Idaho, Louisiana, Nevada, New Mexico, Texas, Washington, Wisconsin	All other states
Assets acquired during marriage are owned 50/50 by both spouses	Assets belong to whoever's name is on the title
Different trust planning may be needed	Traditional trust planning applies

Probate Thresholds and Simplified Processes

Some states allow estates under a certain value to skip formal probate:

State	Simplified Probate Threshold	Notes
California	\$184,500	Real property must go through probate regardless
Texas	\$75,000 (no real estate)	Simplified process available
Florida	\$75,000	Summary administration for small estates
New York	\$50,000	Voluntary administration available

This is why a local estate planning attorney is essential—they know your state's specific rules and shortcuts.

Estate Tax Considerations

Good news: Federal estate tax only applies to estates over \$13.99 million per person in 2025 (\$27.98 million for married couples). Unless you're exceptionally wealthy, you won't face federal estate tax.

However, some states have their own estate or inheritance taxes with much lower thresholds:

- Connecticut: \$13.6 million
- Illinois: \$4 million
- Massachusetts: \$2 million
- Oregon: \$1 million
- And several others with varying thresholds

If you live in a state with estate/inheritance tax, discuss tax-saving strategies with your attorney.

Chapter 11: Next Steps and Action Plan

Congratulations! You now know more about estate planning than 90% of young families. Here's your action plan:

Your 30-Day Estate Planning Roadmap

Week	Action Items	Time Required
Week 1	Complete asset inventory worksheets (Chapter 7); Discuss guardian choices with spouse; Gather financial documents	3-4 hours
Week 2	Research local estate planning attorneys; Have guardian conversation with chosen person; Review beneficiary designations	2-3 hours
Week 3	Schedule attorney consultation; Prepare questions from Chapter 8; Organize documents to bring to meeting	2 hours
Week 4	Attend attorney meeting; Review draft documents; Sign final documents	2-3 hours
After Signing	Fund the trust (transfer assets); Store documents safely; Inform family/guardians of documents	2-4 hours

Finding the Right Attorney

Look for an attorney who:

- ✓ Specializes in estate planning (not general practice)
- ✓ Has experience with young families specifically
- ✓ Offers flat fees (more predictable than hourly)
- ✓ Provides clear explanations without legal jargon
- ✓ Includes trust funding assistance
- ✓ Has good reviews from other families

Maintenance Schedule

Frequency	What to Review
Annually	Beneficiary designations; Asset list completeness; Guardian still willing/able?
After Major Life Events	Birth/adoption; Marriage/divorce; Home purchase; Significant inheritance
Every 3-5 Years	Full document review with attorney; State law changes; Tax law updates

Final Thoughts

Estate planning isn't about pessimism or morbid thoughts—it's about love. It's about ensuring that if the unthinkable happens, your children are cared for by the people you trust, with the resources they need, without court battles or family conflicts.

You've now completed the hardest part: education. You understand the 'why,' the 'what,' and the 'how.' The only thing left is action.

Set a deadline. Put it on your calendar right now. 'Schedule estate planning attorney consultation by [date].' Your future self—and more importantly, your children—will thank you.

You've got this. Your family is worth protecting. Let's make it happen.

Bonus Resources

Guardian Letter of Intent Template

While not legally binding, this letter provides invaluable guidance to your children's guardians:

Letter of Intent for Guardians

To [Guardian Names],

Thank you for agreeing to care for our children if we're unable to. This letter provides guidance about our wishes for raising them:

Education: We value [describe educational priorities]. We'd like them to [continue current school, attend college, etc.].

Religion/Spirituality: [Your wishes regarding religious upbringing].

Activities & Interests: [Child 1] loves [interests]. [Child 2] enjoys [activities]. Please support their passions.

Health & Medical: [Any allergies, conditions, or regular medical care needed].

Routines & Comfort: [Bedtime routines, favorite foods, comfort items, special traditions].

Relationships: Please help them maintain connections with [grandparents, cousins, friends, etc.].

Our Values: [Core values you want instilled: kindness, honesty, hard work, etc.].

With love and gratitude,

[Your Names]

[Date]

Digital Asset Tracker

List passwords and access information for important accounts. Store this securely (password manager, safe, or with your attorney):

Account Type	Login/URL	Password Location
Email (Primary)		
Banking		
Investment Accounts		
Social Media		
Cloud Storage		
Photo Libraries		
Cryptocurrency		
Utilities		
Subscriptions		

Important Contacts List

Keep this with your estate planning documents:

Estate Planning Attorney: _____ Phone: _____

Financial Advisor: _____ Phone: _____

CPA/Accountant: _____ Phone: _____

Life Insurance Agent: _____ Phone: _____

Chosen Guardian: _____ Phone: _____

Backup Guardian: _____ Phone: _____

Trustee: _____ Phone: _____

Document Storage Checklist

After completing your estate plan, make sure:

- Original trust and will documents stored in fireproof safe or safety deposit box
- Copies provided to your chosen guardian and trustee
- Your attorney has copies on file
- Spouse knows where originals are located
- Close family members know documents exist (even if they don't have copies)
- Digital scans stored in secure cloud storage
- Letter of intent provided to guardians separately

Congratulations on taking this important step to protect your family's future!